

Human IRAC Summary Guidelines

1. Purpose of the Human IRAC Summary

For each case in the dataset, human experts will produce a gold-standard IRAC summary that:

- Captures the core legal problem and its resolution.
- Identifies the controlling rules and key authorities.
- Shows how the court applied those rules to the material facts.
- States the bottom-line conclusion clearly and precisely.

These human summaries will serve as the benchmark against which LLM-generated IRAC summaries are evaluated.

The structure builds on standard IRAC/CREAC teaching materials used in legal writing programs, which emphasise identifying the issue, isolating legally relevant facts, stating the applicable rules, analysing how the court applies those rules, and giving a concise conclusion.

2. Output Format and Length

Each human summary must use the following fixed structure:

Header (metadata)

- Case name and neutral citation (e.g. Smith v Jones [2019] HCA 5).
- Court and jurisdiction.
- Area of law (e.g. negligence, contract formation, constitutional review).
- Procedural posture (e.g. appeal from trial judgment, motion to dismiss, judicial review).

IRAC Sections (in this order)

- Issue
- Rule
- Application / Analysis
- Conclusion

Length constraint

- Target: 350 to 600 words for the IRAC body (Issue, Rule, Application, Conclusion), excluding the header.
- If the judgment is exceptionally long or multi-issue, prioritise the primary dispositive issue. Secondary issues may be summarised briefly at the end of Application.

3. General Instructions Before Writing

For each case:

Skim the full judgment once without writing

Note: concentrate on the majority opinion if there are multiple opinions. Only capture concurring/dissenting views if they materially influence the current legal position.

Second reading with marking

Highlight:

- Procedurally significant facts (who sued whom, on what cause of action, relief sought, procedural posture).
- Facts directly connected to the elements of the legal rule.
- The court's statement of the governing test or rule.
- Key passages where the court applies that test to the facts.
- The formal holding and disposition (e.g. appeal allowed, injunction granted).

Rely only on the judgment text

- Do not import background knowledge from headnotes, textbooks, or databases.
- Do not cite outside sources in the summary.

Paraphrase in your own words

- Do not copy long sentences verbatim.
- You may quote very short legal formulations where necessary (e.g. a statutory phrase or a well-known test) with quotation marks.

4. Section-by-Section Guidelines

4.1 Issue

Purpose

Identify the central legal question the court resolves.

Form

- One to two sentences only.
- Frame it as a precise, justiciable question of law, often in "whether ... when / in circumstances where ..." format (adapted from CREAC "Issue Presented" rubrics).
- Focus on the primary dispositive issue. If there are multiple, either: State a general composite issue; or Give one main issue and briefly signal that additional issues were decided (which can be elaborated in Application).

Content

Include:

- The relevant parties (role, not full names: e.g. "employer", "tenant", "public authority").
- The core legal doctrine (e.g. duty of care, offer and acceptance, legitimate expectation).
- The key factual circumstance that makes the issue controversial (e.g. "where the warning was printed on the back of the ticket").

Good Issue example:

Whether a landlord owed a duty of care to a visitor injured in a common stairwell when the landlord had outsourced maintenance to a third-party contractor.

Avoid:

- Overly broad issues: "Whether the defendant was negligent."
- Pure factual questions: "Whether the light was broken."

4.2 Rule

Purpose

State the controlling legal rule(s), test(s), or standard(s) applied to resolve the issue.

Form

- One short paragraph or a few short paragraphs.
- Start with the controlling rule used by the court, not with an abstract treatise on the entire area of law.
- Present rules in element or step form where possible.

Content

Identify:

- Source(s) of law: statute, regulation, constitutional provision, prior cases.
- The operative legal test or elements, in concise prose or explicitly numbered form.
- Any exceptions, defences, or limitations that are central to the court's reasoning (e.g. "obvious risk" exception, "gross negligence" threshold).

Include pinpoint citations to the judgment:

- Use the case's native paragraph or page numbering (e.g. "[35]" or "p. 742").

Example of style:

Rule: A duty of care arises where harm is reasonably foreseeable, there is a relationship of proximity, and it is fair, just and reasonable to impose a duty (at [42]–[45]).

Do not:

- List every citation in the judgment; select only those necessary to understand the rule.
- Treat broad policy discussion as "rule" unless the court crystallises it into a standard.

4.3 Application / Analysis

Purpose

Show how the court applies the rule to the material facts and why it reaches its conclusion. This is the most important part of the summary and should usually be the longest section.

Form

- One to three paragraphs for a straightforward single-issue case; more for complex ones, within the word limit.
- Follow the structure of the rule: walk through each element or step and explain how the court evaluates it.
- Use connective language that explicitly links law and fact ("because", "since", "in light of", "given that").

Content checklist

For each key element of the rule:

- State the element in your own words.
- Identify the fact(s) the court treats as material to that element.
- Explain the court's reasoning.
- Indicate use of precedent.
- Flag any important policy reasoning or doctrinal moves.
- Cite the judgment selectively.

Priorities when space is limited:

Always cover:

- The central element(s) that were actually contested.
- The factual hinge on which the court flipped from one side to the other.

Omit:

- Extended recitation of arguments that did not influence the outcome.
- Minor factual details with no legal significance.

4.4 Conclusion

Purpose

State the bottom-line legal outcome that answers the Issue.

Form

- One sentence; exceptionally two if necessary.
- Locate it at the end of the IRAC.

Content

Explicitly answer the Issue: "The court held that [X], so [legal consequence]."

Include:

- Holding on the key legal question (e.g. "no duty of care", "contract was formed", "decision was invalid for procedural unfairness").
- Procedural disposition (e.g. appeal allowed/dismissed, judgment set aside, matter remitted, damages award upheld).

5. Style and Language Constraints

To promote comparability across cases and jurisdictions:

Neutral, analytic tone

Avoid advocacy, evaluative adjectives, or speculation about what the court "should have" done.

Plain, precise language

- Use standard legal terminology (e.g. "tort", "consideration", "legitimate expectation") where necessary.
- Avoid unnecessary jargon and overly long sentences; favour clarity over literary style.

Third-person perspective

Refer to "the court", "the plaintiff", "the respondent", etc., rather than "we" or "I".

No footnotes

All citations go inline, using the chosen short form for the project (case name + para/page number).

Consistency across summaries

- Use consistent labels for sections (Issue, Rule, Application, Conclusion).
- Use consistent format for citations and for referring to parties.

6. Handling Multiple Issues, Parties, or Opinions

Multiple issues

If the court clearly structures the judgment around two or three discrete issues, you may either:

- Organise Application by sub-headings (e.g. "Application – duty", "Application – breach"), or
- Follow one continuous Application that moves through each issue logically.

The Issue and Conclusion should still be as unified as possible, focusing on the main dispositive question.

Multiple parties

- Focus on the relationships that matter to the legal reasoning (e.g. employer–employee, landowner–visitor, regulator–licensee).
- Only distinguish among multiple plaintiffs/defendants when their positions are legally different.

Multiple opinions

For benchmarking, the default is the majority/controlling opinion.

Mention concurring or dissenting views only if:

- They articulate an alternative rule that is doctrinally significant, or
- The majority explicitly engages with them in its reasoning.

If you include them, do so briefly in Application, clearly marking them as "dissenting" or "concurring".

7. Optional Quality Scoring Rubric for Human Summaries

If you wish to assess the quality of human summaries (for inclusion as a covariate in the benchmarking study, or to filter low-quality gold standards), you may use the following 5-dimension, 20-point rubric, inspired by common CREAC/IRAC grading rubrics in legal writing courses.

Each dimension is scored 0 to 4:

Dimension	4 – Excellent	3 – Good	2 – Adequate	1–0 – Poor / Missing
1. Structural IRAC compliance	All required sections present, clearly labelled; logical order; header complete.	All sections present; minor labelling or ordering issues.	One section weakly developed or header incomplete.	One or more sections missing or seriously flawed.
2. Legal accuracy & completeness	Accurately identifies controlling rule(s), elements, and disposition; no material misstatements; captures main doctrinal move(s).	Minor omissions or slight imprecision that do not change the outcome.	Omits or misstates at least one important element, precedent, or aspect of the holding.	Serious errors in rule or outcome; summary misleading.
3. Factual relevance	Includes all material facts and omits non-essential detail; clear link between facts and legal issues.	Mostly focused on material facts, with minor irrelevant details or minor omissions.	Mixed: some key facts missing and several irrelevant details included.	Facts largely incomplete or dominated by irrelevant detail.
4. Analytical	Clearly explains how	Generally solid	Analysis	Little or no real

Dimension	4 – Excellent	3 – Good	2 – Adequate	1–0 – Poor / Missing
depth (Application)	each key rule element is applied; shows analogies/distinctions to precedent where relevant; reasoning is coherent and faithful to the judgment.	analysis with some steps compressed or implicit.	superficial; tends to paraphrase or jump from rule to conclusion without clear reasoning.	analysis; essentially a restatement of the holding.
5. Citation quality	Accurate, consistent citation of the judgment (and any key cited cases/statutes) with appropriate pinpoints at analytic steps.	Mostly accurate citations; occasional missing or slightly incorrect pinpoints.	Infrequent or incomplete citations; little attention to pinpoints.	No citations, or consistently incorrect enough to be unusable.

You can:

- Use the total score (0–20) as a filter (e.g. retain only summaries with ≥ 16 as gold standards).
- Record dimension-level scores to analyse which aspects of summary quality affect LLM performance (e.g. whether models perform better against more analytically explicit gold summaries).

8. Minimal Checklist for Annotators

For ease of use, you can give annotators the following short checklist:

Before finalising your summary, confirm that:

- You have a header with case name, court, year, area of law, and procedural posture.
- The Issue is one to two sentences, framed as a clear legal question.
- The Rule section states the controlling test(s) or standard(s) with sources and pinpoints.
- The Application walks through how the court applies the rule to the key facts, including any important analogies or distinctions.
- The Conclusion gives a one-sentence holding and disposition that directly answers the Issue.
- The summary stays within 350–600 words (IRAC body).
- Citations are accurate, internally consistent, and limited to the judgment (and key authorities it relies on).

If all boxes are ticked, the summary should be suitable as a gold-standard benchmark for your LLM evaluation.